

Wizards, kings, and dragons

From the late 12th century, French writers began to create stories for the elite called “chivalric romances.” Often filled with magic, they focused on heroic, questing knights who lived by a code of loyalty, honor, and courtly love. Many of the most famous examples are about King Arthur.

Hinted at in Welsh legend, King Arthur may have been a 6th-century British king who won a victory over invading Saxons. But the story of Arthur as it is now told emerged in British cleric Geoffrey of Monmouth’s *History of the Kings of Britain* (1136). It inspired many Arthurian romances, such as that of French poet Chrétien de Troyes—the first to include the doomed love between Sir Lancelot and Queen Guinevere.

The Arthurian tales are rich in magic, featuring enchanted swords, vanishing castles, the quest for the Holy Grail (said to have miraculous powers, including granting eternal youth), and the famous wizard Merlin. Geoffrey of Monmouth first introduced Merlin, inspired by legendary Welsh prophet and bard Myrddin, in his *Prophetiae Merlini* (1135). In Geoffrey’s interpretation of the legend of Merlin, the British King Vortigern’s vision of a red and a white dragon fighting, shown here, represented the battle between Britons and Saxons—with the white (Saxon) dragon winning. Geoffrey also gave Merlin a magical adversary: the sorceress Morgan le Fay.

“Woe to the red dragon,
for its death hastens:
the white dragon will
seize its caves ...”

MERLIN IN GEOFFREY’S *PROPHETIAE MERLINI*, 1135

